

MI Tri-Share Program Overview for Child Care Providers

The MI Tri-Share Child Care Program ("MI Tri-Share") is a workforce development initiative that allows Michigan employers to offer a highly desirable benefit to help improve employee recruitment and retention. MI Tri-Share removes one significant barrier to employment by making child care affordable for Michigan's working families. With MI Tri-Share, the cost of an employee's child care is shared equally among the employer, the employee, and the State of Michigan- a three-way split. Employers can choose to add an extended MI Tri-Share program ("MI Care-Share") for employees with household incomes above the MI Tri-Share income eligibility threshold. By choosing to offer this option, employers contribute one-third of the child care costs and collect the remaining two-thirds from each participating employee.

MI Tri-Share is housed within the Michigan Department of Lifelong Education, Advancement, and Potential ("MiLEAP"). Employers are engaged and recruited by regional facilitator hubs with administration provided by the program's statewide administrative partner ("SAP"), Heart of West Michigan United Way ("HWMUW").

Family choice is prioritized in the MI Tri-Share program. Eligible families can continue using their preferred licensed child care provider, and providers benefit from more predictable revenue, as full-care cost payments are made through SAP. Providers invoice SAP for the total cost of care and receive full payments directly from SAP. The only eligibility requirement for child care providers is that you are licensed in the State of Michigan.

How eligibility works: Employers can opt into the program by signing an Agreement with SAP. Once an employer has opted in, their employees apply at MITriShare.org, and SAP determines each applicant's eligibility. Families must meet all program and employer criteria to participate in the MI Tri-Share program. Families eligible or currently enrolled in the Child Development and Care (CDC) scholarship program must use the CDC benefit.

How payment works: When an eligible employee with an existing licensed child care provider enters the MI Tri-Share program, SAP sends the provider the paperwork needed to pay the provider for their care services. SAP becomes the payer for the total cost of care. The only change for providers is that invoices will now be submitted to SAP rather than to the family.

Providers will receive payments via ACH, which are directly deposited into their bank accounts after they bill for services. Invoices for current or past care dates submitted by 5 pm Friday will be paid the following Friday. Invoices for future care dates (that begin more than one week in the future) submitted by 5 pm Friday will be paid the Friday before the care date begins.

MI Tri-Share payments are made according to the provider's policies and must align with the rates and rules that apply to all families. For instance, providers cannot raise rates for families because of their participation in the MI Tri-Share program. Providers can use their standard billing cycle in the MI Tri-Share program, provided all invoices for care are submitted by the last day of the month of care. These processes are designed to be simple and adaptable, not creating additional administrative burdens for providers.

After the provider is paid, SAP is reimbursed for the care costs paid out in the previous month. Employers collect the employee's portion (most set up payroll deductions), match the contributions, and then forward those funds to SAP as invoiced. SAP uses the state funds to add the last one-third.

Additional Program Details

- Any licensed child care provider in Michigan can provide care for children aged 0-12 in both the MI Tri-Share and MI Care-Share programs. Employers can choose to extend this age up to 17 years old. Depending on the employer's guidelines, the benefit can cover full-time and part-time care, preschool, before- and after-school care, summer care, summer camps, or a combination of these options.
- MI Tri-Share covers only direct care costs; it does not cover registration fees, slot-holding fees, one-time fees, late fees, past-due balances, or other similar charges. These fees will need to be paid at 100% by the family.
- Employees may change child care schedules and rates at any time with 30 days' prior notice. This timeframe allows their employers to accommodate changes in payment arrangements and ensure that provider invoices are paid properly.
- If a family withdraws their child from care or a provider terminates the care arrangement, the MI Tri-Share payments cease on the date the child leaves the program. The provider must advise SAP requires that when a child has been withdrawn from the program, and must submit a final invoice for payment prior to or within one week of the child's last day.
- If a family's employment status changes with a participating MI Tri-Share employer, the benefit ends on the termination date. The family becomes responsible for 100% of their care costs with the provider.
- Funding for the MI Tri-Share program is a part of the state budget. If there are any changes to the program, you will be notified.

If you have additional questions, encounter a problem, or want to offer suggestions to improve the MI Tri-Share program, please get in touch with SAP via email at MITriShare@hwmuw.org.